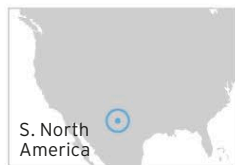
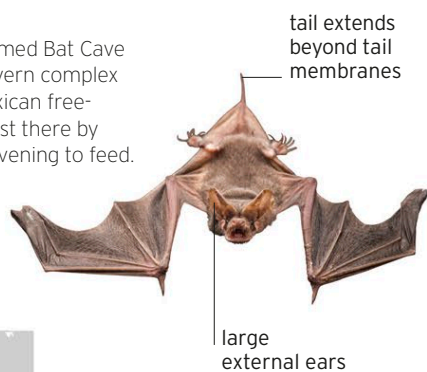


▷ NIGHT HUNTER

Living in the aptly named Bat Cave at the start of the cavern complex are thousands of Mexican free-tailed bats, which roost there by day and leave each evening to feed.



Carlsbad Caverns

A vast underground cave system containing a stunning array of calcite formations

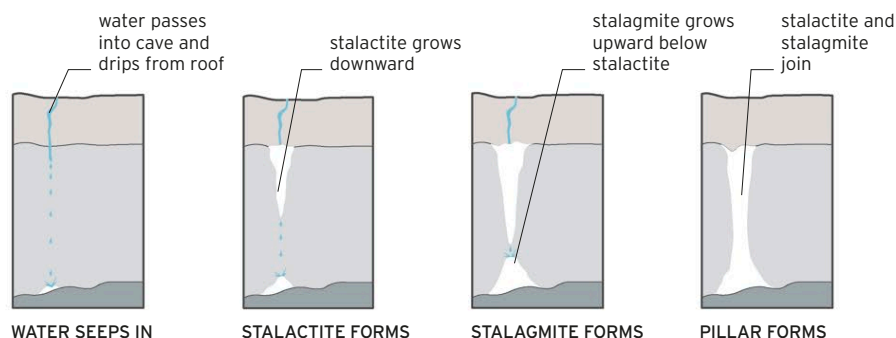
Beneath the Chihuahuan Desert in the Guadalupe Mountains, New Mexico, lies a series of massive underground chambers and passages decorated with stalactites and stalagmites. The caverns formed through an unusual process in which groundwater, rich in sulfuric acid, invaded and dissolved the limestone rock on a huge scale. Only later did percolating rainwater enter the resulting caves and furnish their interiors with the elaborate calcite formations seen today. The famous Big Room, a rambling chamber up to 625 ft (191 m) wide in places, contains many remarkable features, including the Hall of Giants—a series of gigantic stalagmites rising almost 65 ft (20 m) from the cave floor—and the Painted Grotto, colored by iron oxide and hydroxide pigments.



STALACTITES, STALAGMITES, AND PILLARS

As mineral-saturated water seeps through the roof of a cave and drips down, a residue starts to build up and a stalactite forms. As drops of

water hit the ground, they gradually create a mound of residue that grows into a stalagmite. Over time, the two may join to create a pillar.



◁△ ELABORATE DECORATIONS

Many of the caverns' roofs are covered with delicate tubular stalactites called straws, formed by water moving slowly through cracks in the rock. Curtainlike deposits of calcite, called flowstones (left), form when water runs down the cavern walls.